from outside are frequently prevented from entering the States. In the middle 'twenties Mr. C. R. Das was very ill and he decided to go to Kashmir to recuperate. He was not on a political mission. He journeyed right up to the Kashmir border, but was stopped there. Even Mr. M. A. Jinnah was debarred from entering Hyderabad State, and Mrs. Sarojini Naidu, whose home is in Hyderabad city, was not permitted to go there for a long period.

When such conditions prevail in the States it would have been natural for the Congress to stand up for the elementary rights of the people of the States and to criticise their wholesale suppression. But Gandhiji fathered a novel policy on the Congress in regard to the States—the "policy of non-interference in the internal administration of the States." This hush-hush policy has been adhered to by him in spite of the most extraordinary and painful occurrences in the States, and in spite of wholly unprovoked attacks by the States' governments on the Congress. Apparently the fear is that Congress criticism might offend the Rulers and make it more difficult to 'convert' them. In a letter written in July 1934 by Gandhiji to Mr. N. C. Kelkar, the President of the States Subjects' Conference, he reiterated his conviction that the policy of non-interference was both wise and sound, and the view he took of the legal and constitutional position of these States was most extraordinary. "The States," he wrote, "are independent entities under British law. That part of India which is described as British has no more power to shape the policy of the States than it has, say, that of Afghanistan or Ceylon." It is not surprising that even the mild and moderate Indian States' People's Conference and the Liberals took exception to his views and his advice.

But these views were welcome enough to the Rulers of the States, and they took advantage of them. Within a month the Travancore Government banned the National Congress in its territories and stopped all its meetings and its enrolment of members. In doing so, it stated that 'responsible leaders' had themselves given this advice—obviously hinting at Gandhiji's statement. This ban, it might be noted, was after the withdrawal of the Civil Disobedience movement in British India (the States had never been involved in the movement) and when the Congress had been declared a legal organisation again by the Government of India. It is also interesting to note that the chief political adviser of the Travancore Government at the tims was (and still is) Sir C. P. Ramaswamy Aiyar, once a General Secretary of the Congress as well as of the Home Rule